on March 2, 1974. In reality, Ne Win maintained total control of the Burmese government.

Problems engulfed the new administration from the start. Flooding during the summer of 1974 led to a cholera epidemic, which the government was unable to handle. At the same time, the regime was trying to quell economic crisis on several fronts.

The final crisis of 1974 occurred when retired UN Secretary-General U Thant died in November. Ne Win refused to grant a state funeral for possibly the most prominent international figure to emerge from Burma. Historic animosity between Win and Thant dated back to the 1950s. Over 50,000 student protesters turned out wanting Thant to receive proper burial and the honor deserving such an important world leader. The military refused to grant a state service and initially closed the universities and cut off communications with the outside world. As the protests turned violent, bloodshed ensued with over 4,000 arrests, and 74 protesters wounded and 9 killed. Martial law was declared in Rangoon for the next 18 months. Universities were closed and reopened on several occasions during this period.

In addition to student unrest, Ne Win faced growing opposition from Buddhist activists. The BSPP believed that the leaders of the Buddhist community were in collusion with the student activities during the turmoil of late 1974. The government responded by attempting to purge and purify the monastic order. The government now required that all members of the monkhood had to register with the authorities. At the same time, Ne Win attempted to gain favor by releasing 14,000 political prisoners and striving for reconciliation with former enemies, including U Nu. Numerous individuals who were involved in antigovernment activities several years earlier were allowed to return, under the condition that they stay out of politics.

The later years of the BSPP were plagued with threats to Ne Win, some real and some perceived. Multiple plots were uncovered during the late 1970s and 1980s. Several BSPP members were gaining in popularity at the expense of the longtime leader. A party vote taken in the late 1970s showed greater support for San Yu. Because of this unfavorable vote 113 party members were purged out of the party. The overall opinion was that the